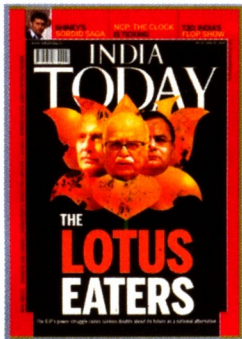


The Lotus Eaters

JUNE 29, 2009

A tired and discredited leadership short on ideas and a demoralised cadre see the Bharatiya Janata Party sink to a new low. A major overhaul is due if the party is to bounce back.



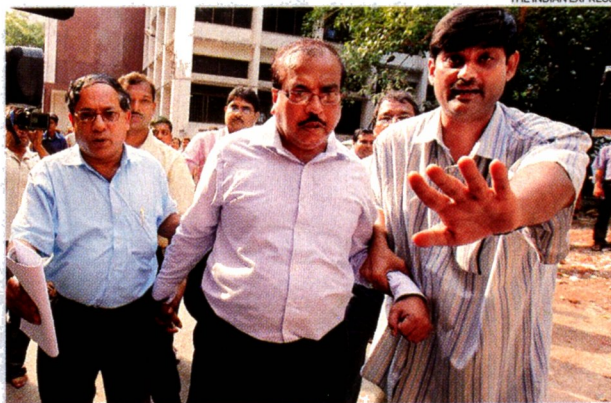
“The infighting in the BJP and massive victory for the Sonia Gandhi-led Congress establishes the fact that all political parties need an undisputed leader acting like a pillar for their survival.”

SUBHASH CHANDRA AGRAWAL, via www.indiatoday.in

Saffron Setback

Your cover story (“The Lotus Eaters”, June 29) by Prabhu Chawla made an excellent analysis for the debacle of the BJP in the 2009 elections, but not without a subtle bias against L.K. Advani and Rajnath Singh. That cracks appeared in the party ‘with a difference’ right from the start of the electoral process and that too from senior leaders like Arun Jaitley is indisputable. Even now it is not too late to review the Hindutva plank and take a pragmatic view suited to today’s thinking, and come out of the fundamentalist label. GANTI MAHAPATRUNI RAMA RAO, Visakhapatnam

The organisational rumblings in the BJP might lead to thwarting of the bipolar phenomenon in



Weakening the Nation

It’s shameful that corruption continues unabated in defence deals (“Factories of Graft”, June 29). The accused, Sudipta Ghosh, needs to be summarily punished after a speedy trial. All benami assets, even if “regularised” but proven to have been procured through such ill-gotten wealth, should be confiscated. ANJUM M. SAMEL, Mumbai

It is a pity that kickbacks are still being paid in defence deals, putting the security of the country at stake. The guilty in the Ordnance Factory Board scandal must be given exemplary punishment to prevent their occurrence in future. V.K. TANGRI, Dehradun

Indian politics, as your excellent study points out. The consequence would either be morphing of the Congress party into its former oppressive avatar, or resuscitation of the third and the fourth front chimera. It is for the BJP to forestall these scenarios by nursing its left-over aspirations. BISHAN SAHAI, via www.indiatoday.in

States of Affairs

I read two stories on Bihar and Punjab (“Equal to the Test” and “High and Dry”, June 29). The stories show an interesting paradox. Despite lacking basic amenities, the students in Bihar achieved seats in IITs, while the youth in Punjab are increasingly getting addicted to narcotics. All educational institutions in the country